him—to expose to the public what he had found and risk the consequences.

Other Avenues of Dissent

In August 2013, President Obama said Snowden could have avoided criminal charges if he had simply told his superiors about the abuses he had become aware of. Obama was referring to an executive order he had recently signed protecting intelligence employees as whistle-blowers. But the executive order did not apply to government contractors such as Snowden.

Snowden also contended that, at various times, he had voiced his concerns. He said he informed NSA colleagues in 2012 about his discovery that the NSA was collecting more

OATH OF SECRECY

NSA Director Keith Alexander and Director of National Intelligence James Clapper said Snowden broke an oath of secrecy, specifically Standard Form 312, the classified-information nondisclosure agreement. Snowden admitted he signed the form, but he has said the oath he chose to keep was to the US Constitution, not a civil contract of secrecy. "That is the oath that I kept that Keith Alexander and James Clapper did not," Snowden said in an interview.[15] He maintained he was not being disloyal to the country, nor was he trying to bring down the NSA; he was working to improve it. Experts counter if this were truly Snowden's belief, he should not have signed the form in the first place.

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